

Novality Crochet Studio

COCO the Capybara

Design Code **NS 04**

No plastic eyes · Intermediate · 2.5 – 3 hours

A low, round, bottom-heavy capybara with a blunt sewn-on muzzle, plump stuffed legs and a calm embroidered sleeping face.

Finished size	Yarn	Hook
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Safety — embroidered face, no plastic parts

Coco has **no safety eyes** and **no small plastic parts**, which makes the face safer than a safety-eyed toy.

That does **not** make the finished toy suitable for babies: Coco is a stuffed toy with a sewn-on muzzle and sewn-on ears, and it has **not been tested** to a toy-safety standard such as ASTM F963 or EN 71.

Intended as a decorative item, or a gift for a child old enough not to chew it. Check every seam — especially the muzzle and ears — before giving Coco to a young child.

Materials

- **Main yarn** — Worsted weight (#4), warm brown, about 30 g. A smooth matte yarn shows the stitch texture best.
- **Face yarn** — Worsted weight (#4), dark brown, about 5 g, for the closed eyes, nose and mouth. Use the same weight as the main yarn.
- **Hook** — 3.0 mm (US C-2 or D-3). The gauge is written for this hook.
- **Eyes** — None. The sleeping face is embroidered — no safety eyes.
- **Also needed** — Polyester fiber filling about 5–8 g; yarn needle; stitch marker; pins. Pins matter: the muzzle and ears are pinned before sewing.

Gauge & finished size

Gauge: 36 sc around measures about **52 mm** in diameter when stuffed (4.5 mm per stitch, 4.3 mm per round).

Check it on the body **after Rnd 6** — a stuffed tube, not a flat swatch. If your 36 sts measure wider than 52 mm, crochet more tightly or go down a hook size; a loose gauge will show stuffing.

Finished size: about 10.3 cm (4 in) tall, 5 cm (2 in) wide.

Abbreviations

Abbr	Meaning	Abbr	Meaning
MR	magic ring	sl st	slip stitch
ch	chain	st(s)	stitch(es)
sc	single crochet	Rnd(s)	round(s)
inc	increase (2 sc in one st)	FO	fasten off
invdec	invisible decrease	(n)	stitch count at round end

Work in a **continuous spiral** — do not join and do not chain 1 between rounds. Keep a marker in the first stitch of every round. Work every stitch through both loops unless a note says otherwise.

Techniques

- 1 · **The magic ring** — Every piece begins with a magic ring. Pull the tail tight once the first round is complete.
- 2 · **Working in a spiral** — Keep a stitch marker in the first stitch of every round and move it up. There is no seam and no join to count from.
- 3 · **The two-layer leg join** — This is the only fiddly step — worth practicing once on a scrap magic ring. Hold a finished leg against the body with the pinched-flat top of the leg lying against the outside of the body. Insert the hook through **BOTH** the leg and the body stitch and work one single crochet; the leg edge and body stitch are treated as one stitch. They still count as one stitch each, so every count in the body table stays correct. Pinch the leg top flat first — a round, un-pinched top will not lie against the curved body and the join will pucker.
- Pinching the leg top** — A 9-stitch leg top flattens to about 5 stitches across — pinch it down to a strip about 3 stitches wide and hold it while you join. The stitches you don't join bunch up inside, and that bunch makes the leg look plump rather than tubular. Don't keep the top flat and wide.

How the height adds up

Part	Calculation	Result
Body, Rnd 1–20	20 rnd × 4.3 mm	86 mm
Legs lift the body off the table	short 8/9-round legs	17 mm
Total standing height	86 + 17	103 mm = 10.3 cm

Part 1 · Legs

Make **2 back legs (8 rounds)** and **2 front legs (9 rounds)**. Stuff the lower half of each leg lightly, leaving the top loose. Back legs stop after Rnd 8; front legs work Rnd 9 too — they join one round higher and need to be one round longer so all four feet reach the table level.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	all four
R2	[1 sc, inc] x 3	(9)	all four
R3	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R4	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R5	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R6	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R7	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R8	sc in each st around	(9)	BACK legs finish here
R9	sc in each st around	(9)	FRONT legs only

Finish: FO with a long tail for sewing. Before joining, pinch the whole 9-stitch top flat into a narrow strip about 3 stitches wide (see technique 3).

Part 1 · Ear and Muzzle

EAR — make 2 (do not stuff)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)
R2	[1 sc, inc] x 3	(9)
R3	sc in each st around	(9)

FO with a long tail, do not stuff — a shallow cup.

MUZZLE — make 1 (stuff lightly)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)
R2	[1 sc, inc] x 3	(9)
R3	[2 sc, inc] x 3	(12)
R4	sc in each st around	(12)
R5	sc in each st around	(12)

FO with a long tail and stuff lightly, just enough to hold a dome; it should sit proud of the head when sewn on.

Part 2 · Body and Head

Both are 36 stitches around with only a shallow waist between them — that is what makes Coco read as one round blob rather than a snowman. The legs are joined low at Rnd 4–5.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	
R3	[1 sc, inc] x 6	(18)	
R4	3 sc, [1 sc, inc] x 3, 3 sc, [1 sc, inc] x 3	(24)	join the BACK legs
R5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	(30)	join the FRONT legs
R6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	(36)	full width — check gauge
R7	sc in each st around	(36)	
R8	sc in each st around	(36)	
R9	sc in each st around	(36)	stuff the body FIRMLY
R10	[7 sc, invdec] x 4	(32)	shallow waist
R11	[7 sc, inc] x 4	(36)	head begins
R12	sc in each st around	(36)	muzzle over R12–14
R13	sc in each st around	(36)	
R14	sc in each st around	(36)	eyes at R14–15
R15	sc in each st around	(36)	ears at R15
R16	[4 sc, invdec] x 6	(30)	
R17	[3 sc, invdec] x 6	(24)	stuff the head firmly
R18	[2 sc, invdec] x 6	(18)	
R19	[1 sc, invdec] x 6	(12)	top up stuffing
R20	invdec x 6	(6)	

Finish. Cinch the remaining 6 stitches closed and weave the tail inside the body. **Do not decrease the Rnd 10 waist further** — a narrow neck cannot hold the head upright on this shape.

Part 2 · Joining the Legs

Work Rnd 4 and Rnd 5 as the plain increase rounds in the body table, but as you reach each leg position, hold a pinched-flat leg against the body and work the next 3 sc through **BOTH** the leg and the body together (technique 3). Those 3 sc still count as 3 stitches of the round, so the stitch totals do not change — Rnd 4 ends at 24, Rnd 5 at 30.

Rnd 4 — the BACK legs (total 24 stitches)

- 1. Work the first 3 sc through a leg and the body together, then [1 sc, inc] x 3.
- 2. Work the next 3 sc through the second leg and the body together, then [1 sc, inc] x 3 to the end of the round.

Rnd 5 — the FRONT legs (total 30 stitches)

Work Rnd 5 as the increase round [3 sc, inc] x 6, keeping all 6 increases.

Position the leg joins within that round: **work 7 stitches · join a leg over the next 3 stitches · work 10 stitches · join a leg over the next 3 stitches · work 7 stitches** to the end.

That is $7 + 3 + 10 + 3 + 7 = 30$ stitches. The 6 increases are worked inside the 7 / 10 / 7 sections and are **counted in those totals** — do not add them separately. Rnd 4's 24 stitches are used exactly.

The 7-10-7 spacing centres each front leg between the two back legs. **Work the numbers exactly.** If the front legs line up directly behind the back legs instead of between them, the footprint narrows and Coco tips. Hold the piece upside down and check all four legs sit square before you stuff the body.

Part 3 · Why the legs join so low

The legs join low (Rnd 4–5) so every foot hangs **about 17 mm below the body** and Coco stands on her feet, not her belly.

Why the legs join so low. Back legs (8 rnd, ~34 mm) join at Rnd 4, only 17 mm above the base; front legs (9 rnd, ~39 mm) join at Rnd 5, 21 mm up. Different lengths, same result: every foot hangs about 17 mm below the body so all four land level. This is the most common failure on round-bodied animals.

Part 4 · Face and Assembly

Muzzle — Stuff lightly and pin it to the front of the head over Rnd 12–14, centered, then sew all the way around with matching brown. It should sit proud of the head, not flush. Centering matters — the eyes go 6 stitches apart and a muzzle pinned even slightly off-center crowds one eye.

Eyes — Embroider — do not use safety eyes. With dark brown, work a shallow downward arc about 3 stitches wide on each side, at Rnd 14–15, 6 stitches apart, with a tiny tick angled down at each outer end. This closed-eye curve is what makes Coco look asleep.

Nose & mouth — Embroider **AFTER** the muzzle is sewn on, so the stitches sit on the finished curve. On the muzzle, work a small dark triangle at top center, a short vertical line down from it, and a soft curved mouth to one side.

Ears — Pinch the base of each ear so it cups forward, then sew at Rnd 15, about 5 stitches apart, angled slightly outward. Rnd 15 is a full 36-st round, so this puts the ears on top of the head where a capybara's belong.

Legs — The legs were joined during Rnd 4–5 — there is nothing to sew. Just check each pinched 3-stitch strip is caught fully in the round.

Final shaping — Roll the finished piece gently between your palms to settle the stuffing into a round, bottom-heavy shape.

Before you sew — lay every component out and check:

- 4 legs (2 back of 8 rounds, 2 front of 9) · 2 ears · 1 muzzle · 1 body & head, closed at the crown.
- The sleeping face is all embroidery — closed-eye arcs, a small triangle nose and a soft curved mouth.

Troubleshooting

- **Coco looks too tall.** Almost always too many plain rounds. Rnd 12–15 is the straight head section the face is positioned on; adding “just one more” round turns the shape into a tower and moves the face.
- **Coco will not stand.** Check the join height, not the leg spacing. The legs belong on Rnd 4 and Rnd 5; joined any higher, they cannot clear the underside of the body and the belly rests on the table.
- **Coco tips forward or backward.** Most often the front legs are lined up behind the back legs instead of between them — the Rnd 5 spacing must be 7 sc, 10 sc, 7 sc. If still tipping, stuff the lower body more firmly and settle weight back over all four feet.
- **Rocks back, front feet in the air.** All four legs are the same length and they cannot be. Front legs join at Rnd 5 (21 mm up), back at Rnd 4 (17 mm up); work the front legs 9 rounds and the back legs 8.
- **The head flops back.** The Rnd 10 waist is deliberately shallow at 32 stitches — do not decrease it further. A narrow neck cannot hold the head upright.
- **Small hole where a leg meets the body.** You joined a flat, wide leg top instead of a pinched one. Flatten the whole 9-stitch top into a strip about 3 stitches wide before joining, so the un-joined stitches bunch up inside.
- **Muzzle looks flat / stuffing shows.** Stuff the muzzle just enough to hold a dome. If stuffing shows through the body, your gauge is too loose — 36 sts should measure 52 mm; crochet tighter or go down a hook size.

Colorways

Classic warm brown · Soft grey · Sandy beige · Cocoa

Designer Notes

Bottom-heavy by design. Stuff the lower body firmly and keep the shape squat. Coco is meant to be one continuous curve from base to crown — she stands on her feet, not her belly.

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Safety reminder

This pattern has not been tested to a toy-safety standard (ASTM F963 / EN 71). Although Coco has no plastic parts, finished items made for sale must be assessed by the seller against local toy-safety laws. Reinforce all sewn-on parts before giving to a young child.

Happy crocheting!

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